

The Answer Is... Competence, Integrity, and Productivity ...What Is the Question?

The question is "What defines a *professional* systems analyst or programmer?"

We now have legally important answers to this question from the Wage and Hour Division of the U.S. Department of Labor and from the National Labor Relations Board.* These two regulatory bodies have found that persons with job titles of "programmer" or "systems analyst" are not classifiable as *professionals* under the definitions used in regulations that determine status for overtime pay and collective bargaining.

The impact on ACM may be important in the long term.

Let's look at a few facts that indicate why: • Nearly 55 percent of ACM members are directly involved in programming or systems analysis. A crucial factor in the regulatory rulings is the lack of availability of a baccalaureate degree in programming or systems analysis. While 92 percent of ACM members have college degrees, not 1 percent have such a degree in programming or systems analysis. • The Wage and Hour Division also found that "the computer sciences are not generally recognized by colleges and universities as a bona fide academic discipline. . . ." • Another crucial factor is the lack of availability of a formal certification process in the fields covered. Of ACM members 87 percent hold no professional certificate of any kind; 6.5 percent have the CDP issued by DPMA, 6 percent have professional engineering registrations, and the remainder hold CPAs or miscellaneous other licenses.

These indicators appear to place

*See page 129 and 125 of this issue.

ACM squarely at the crossroads which has been occupied, uncomfortably, by a number of other technical societies during the past year or two: Do we remain strictly a technical society in accordance with the present charter? or Do we become a society having a primary concern for the welfare of its members? There have been strong voices raised within ACM urging a move toward this latter mode of operation similar to a Guild.

The actions by the Department of Labor, the NLRB, and the courts have convinced me beyond doubt that the future of ACM is dependent upon retaining the role of a *technical society*. Doing so may, in fact, provide the *only* viable answers to the question of what defines status in programming and systems analysis. By this, I mean that the day may be close when employers and others may make the determination of legal status solely on the basis of whether the programmer or systems analyst involved is a member of ACM—and therefore technically qualified. Along the way we must also work to correct the public impression that computer science is not a learned profession.

The ACM membership adopted a constitutional change last year that clearly paves the way to a determination of legal status. By declaring competence and integrity of our members to be essential to continued achievement of ACM's objectives, we have set in motion the steps necessary to achieve two components of the answer in the title above.

But assurances of competence and integrity are not enough in the particular instance of programmers and

systems analysts. A third component, productivity, is at least equally important.

The decline of programmer productivity over the past decade, if continued, could approach the proportions of a national scandal. A number of key people (Herb Grosch's and Dick Hamming's names leap to mind) have issued public warnings, but little has been done about their concerns.

Beneath these concerns lies an urgent issue. Who among today's programmers and systems analysts is engaged in a disciplined, personal effort to improve the tools, techniques, organizations, and attitudes that determine their own productivity and that of their associates, i.e. the true professional? Conversely, who among these people is conducting organized efforts which effectively restrict the quantity and quality of programming activities, i.e. the non-professional?

My discussions with ACM members lead me to believe that we have as members a predominance of the people who are trying to improve productivity.

I would like to see ACM begin a program that achieves the qualification of every ACM member for suitable status in the eyes of the law and in the eyes of society in general. Such status is not granted—it is earned. The project will be a difficult one. Our associates in the British Computer Society have found a way to achieve this goal. The Canadians have begun action.

The question is asked in the U.S. Let ACM give the answer!

—W.M. Carlson